PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Kansas–Nebraska Act — House & Divided

Reading the Law — and Its Fuse

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Kansas–Nebraska Act — House & Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Two short sources sit at the heart of this fight: the Act in its own words, and the answer a little-known Illinois lawyer gave it. Read both, then trace how one clause set off a chain reaction

THE SOURCES

SOURCE A · THE LAW ITSELF · 1854 — The Kansas–Nebraska Act

> *"…the eighth section of the act preparatory to the admission of Missouri … [the Missouri Compromise] … is hereby declared inoperative and void; it being the true intent and meaning of this act not to legislate slavery into any Territory or State, nor to exclude it therefrom, but to leave the people thereof perfectly free to form and regulate their domestic institutions in their own way, subject only to the Constitution…"*
> *— Kansas–Nebraska Act, 1854. Public domain (U.S. Statutes at Large)*

— Kansas–Nebraska Act, 1854. Public domain (U.S. Statutes at Large).

SOURCE B · THE REPLY · OCTOBER 16, 1854 — Lincoln at Peoria

> *"The doctrine of self-government is right — absolutely and eternally right… When the white man governs himself, that is self-government; but when he governs himself, and also governs another man, that is more than self-government — that is despotism. … [Slavery] deprives our republican example of its just influence in the world."*
> *— Abraham Lincoln, Peoria, Illinois, 1854. Public domain*

— Abraham Lincoln, Peoria, Illinois, 1854. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · WHAT THE LAW SAYS

In your own words, what did the Act let the settlers of Kansas and Nebraska decide? Quote the phrase from Source A that says so.

_____

_____

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE COUNTER-ARGUMENT

According to Source B, why does Lincoln say voting to allow slavery is NOT really “self-government”? Put his logic in one or two sentences.

QUESTION 3 STEP 2 · THE COUNTER-ARGUMENT

Lincoln's whole objection depends on one assumption. Which is it?

- ☐ A. that most settlers secretly opposed slavery
- ☐ B. that the enslaved person is a man — a human being, not property
- ☐ C. that Congress, not voters, should build the railroad
- ☐ D. that Kansas was too far north to grow cotton

LINK 1 — THE SPARK STEP 3 · TRACING THE FUSE

CAUSE: The Act erases the Missouri Compromise line. → EFFECT in the North: what new political party is born, and why?

LINK 2 — THE RUSH STEP 3 · TRACING THE FUSE

CAUSE: Slavery in Kansas now depends on a vote. → EFFECT in Kansas: what do both sides do, and what two things go wrong?

LINK 3 — THE RESULT STEP 3 · TRACING THE FUSE

CAUSE: Two fake governments and distrusted elections. → EFFECT: what does the territory become known as, and why is it called a “rehearsal” for civil war?

QUESTION 7 STEP 4 · WHY IT MATTERS

Douglas said he was just letting people govern themselves. In one or two sentences: was popular sovereignty a fair democratic idea, a reckless mistake, or both? Use the sources to defend your answer.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Kansas–Nebraska Act — House & Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The Act let settlers… The phrase is "…"."

QUESTION 2: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Lincoln argues that…"

QUESTION 3: **Correct — B. that the enslaved person is a man — a human being, not property**

Right. Lincoln's logic only works if the enslaved person is a man — a human being with a self to govern. That is the real question the Act tried to dodge.

LINK 1 — THE SPARK: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Because free land could now become slave land, Northerners formed…"

LINK 2 — THE RUSH: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Both sides rush in settlers, which leads to… and…"

LINK 3 — THE RESULT: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Kansas becomes known as… It is a rehearsal because…"

QUESTION 7: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I think popular sovereignty was… because…"